

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Protocols

Spouting TLAs ending with a P is a great way to mark yourself up as a network guru when you're amongst folks who don't know their TCP from their IP. And if your water cooler crowd is doing it all the time, you're going to feel left out. In either case, you'd do well to mug up the following protocol names!

UDP

One of the protocols that allows two programs on a network to send out short messages called datagrams. This is an "unreliable" protocol; data may arrive out of order or go missing. Something like your boss' SMS never reaching you.

TCP

A "reliable" protocol, TCP allows applications in networked systems to exchange data. TCP ensures data is received in the order in which it was sent—like how your girlfriend very effectively communicates what she wants you to buy for her!

ICMP

Used by networked computers' OSes to send error messages, such as a router not being reachable. Straightforward enough...

RTP

Real-time Transport Protocol is used to send streaming audio and video packets over the Internet. Like when your mother-in-law is incessantly screaming and gesticulating at the same time.

ARP

Address Resolution Protocol is used to find the hardware address if the IP address of the destination is known. Like a postman finding a town from the PIN code.

SMTP

Simple Mail Transfer Protocol is a text-based protocol that e-mail clients use. It works on top of TCP, and is the best thing to have happened to us since pigeon post.

We're Not Grown-ups!

Our cover story this month was quite the talk of the office. Sex is still controversial enough to cause a stir—even in an office of geeks who have reportedly seen all there is to see in technology! When Agent 001 walked in after a week's absence, clutching his "Sex" story, he seemed pale and... drained. "Viral fever," he explained. No-one believed him!

Then there were the problems of explaining it all to the graphic designers and layout artists. They had to come up with visuals and ideas of how to depict what kids face online, without hurting too many sentiments. What you see are blurred / censored images, but our designers were "exposed" to the originals. Some were only too happy, but others, like Sivalal S, were too embarrassed to

work on the images. When Pillai-ji (Shivasankaran Pillai) was laying out the story, a lot of people gathered around, hoping for a free show—much to Deepak Ajwani's consternation! Too bad for them that all the images had already been censored!

Then there were the fights between the liberals and conservatives: The "that image just *has* to go" vs. the "why, what's wrong with it" kind! This was promptly followed by an "I-have-more-porn-on-my-hard-disk-at-home-than-you" competition by some of our more liberal colleagues! At the end of it all we think we've done a decent job of tastefully portraying the truth that's out there.

We can now finally get back to the more familiar territory of gadgets and gizmos, and leave all that porn behind us!

DIGIT DIARY

Anyway, will de-sexing games, including emotions and attachments and possibly even relationships, and including less action and more human interaction do it for women? Say a game like *Bob and Alice: The Untold Story* or something along those lines?

Perhaps. But no-one knows what women want, including women!

ROBOPHILES AT LARGE?

Keeping The Bots Under Control

Especially in Japan—but in other countries as well—robots are increasingly coming into homes and workplaces. Robotics experts are now getting more and more concerned about safety implications, and have come together to try to find ways to prevent robots from harming people. Reminds us of Asimov and the Three Laws of Robotics. Apparently, apart from safety, sex is one of the big concerns in regard to robots becoming more popular: for example, should robotic sex dolls resembling teenagers be legally allowed? Sit back a minute and think

about the technology landscape today: people are actually getting concerned about robo-sex and robo-paedophilia!

The issues may seem far out now, but in the next few years they will become increasingly relevant, according to experts. It's apparently high time we think of things such as the robots turning against us, and about robo-sex.

Regulating the behaviour of robots is going to become even more difficult in the future, since they will increasingly have self-learning mechanisms inbuilt. Their behaviour could become impossible to predict.

Probably the area likely to prove most controversial is the development of robotic sex toys, says Dr Henrik Christensen, chairman of the European Robotics Network at the Swedish Royal Institute of Technology. "People are going to be having sex with robots in the next five years," he says. (And dead serious he sounds, too.) These robots will initially be pretty basic, but that is unlikely to put people off, he says. "People are willing to have sex with inflatable dolls, so initially anything that moves will be an improvement."

One thing we aren't clear about is, why the emphasis on sex? Who cares if a few perverts decide to indulge in robo-sex? It might even be of therapeutic value, and at least they won't be out on the streets looking for kids! As regards robot safety, wouldn't the emergency switch-off button work fine enough? Even if the behaviour of the robots can't be predicted, why should we assume that they will function in a *destructive* manner? After all, they're supposed to be programmed to be smart—so why not expect them earn their keep in a decent manner?

All this reeks of sci-fi-inspired paranoia—or probably another case of research for the sake of it.

CHEATIN' STUDENTS

Wales: Don't Blame Me!

A survey conducted by CBSNews has found that one in five American teenagers uses the Internet to cheat on school assignments. As expected, there's a difference between the sexes: 24 per cent of boys and 14 per cent of girls have plagiarised material online at least once.